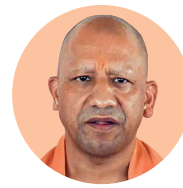


tified, its streets and hotels abuzz with the anticipation of millions. For ordinary devotees, the government's arrangements offer a total of 150,000 tents. Hygiene and sustainability are priorities like never before. Some 150,000 toilets and 25,000 dustbins ensure the holy grounds remain unblemished—bestowing this aura of sanctity are 15,000 sanitation workers, with 160 waste management vehicles. QR-based platforms streamline access to the amenities. For those moments of panic, 10 lost and found centres will be a beacon of solace.

The true seeker, of course, only looks for the portals of salvation. Here, pilgrims will find thoughtful enhancements—29 temples radiating renewed beauty, strung along 11 new corridors, and 12 km of ghats interlinked by 8 km of riverfront roads. This is where faith transits across the earthly aura of 69,000 LED and solar hybrid lights to meet the sacred waters. The beating heart of the Kumbh will be these sanctifying bathing rituals, or *snans*. These are punctuated by grand processions and culminate in the Shahi Snans—the mela's spiritual pinnacles. The sequence of events runs from the first holy dip on Paush Purnima (Jan. 13), the spirit of charity of Makar Sankranti (Jan. 14), the silence and purification of Mauni Amavasya (Jan. 29), the yellow-hued renewal of Basant Panchami (Feb. 3), the serene white of Maghi Purnima (Feb. 12) to the spiritual crescendo of Mahashivaratri (Feb. 26).



"Once Kumbh was known for chaos and stampedes. We have transformed it, combining tradition with innovation, receiving UNESCO recognition"

—YOGI ADITYANATH

Chief Minister, Uttar Pradesh

Beyond its spiritual and cultural dimensions, Mahakumbh 2025 holds undeniable political significance for Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath himself. The immense national and international import of the event is not lost on him: "The Mahakumbh is not just a religious congregation, it is a celebration of faith, tradition and heritage that showcases the soul of India to the world." And he wants to present himself as the custodian of that soul. "There was a time when the Kumbh was associated with dirt, chaos and stampedes. Today, under Prime Minister Narendra Modi's guidance, we have transformed it into a symbol of pride, receiving UNESCO recognition in 2019. Mahakumbh 2025 will not only maintain this legacy but set a new benchmark in how faith-based events are organised."

The chief minister is taking a deeply personal interest in every aspect of the Mahakumbh's planning and execution. By turning it into a pristine and well-organised affair, Yogi hopes to solidify his image as a leader who respects tradition while embracing progress and also showcase Uttar Pradesh as a hub of spiritual grandeur and administrative excellence. "This is an opportunity for Uttar Pradesh to display its administrative capability, hospitality and respect for our Sanatan culture." His vision is clear: a "Digital Kumbh" with advanced technologies to aid devotees, coupled with eco-conscious measures like zero plastic usage and sewage treatment to preserve the purity of the Ganga and Yamuna. "We aim to make this Mahakumbh a transformative experience for visitors, combining ancient traditions with modern innovation," he emphasises.

An Uneven Ganga

But exit the well-appointed enclaves of the rich, and one also enters the dark waters where ancient India bequeaths its curses along with its blessings. The Mahakumbh also showcases the stark contrast between grandeur and struggle, luxury and deprivation coexisting in unsettling proximity. Once considered a "*dehaat ka mela*", a rural festival accessible to all, the Kumbh is now an extravagant affair the poor and middle class can scarcely afford. Modern India likes to take its holy dips in flowing prosperity; symbols of exclusivity, like the Rs 1 lakh per night pads at the shiny new Tent City, have pride of place.

Epic in scale, even in its outlay—a deluge at Rs 7,000 crore—the mela of 2025 bids fair to secure its place in history as the world's largest spiritual gathering. Simultaneously, it will be seen as a landmark in the harmonising of tradition, technological innovation and cooperative effort, offering a prototype for large-scale events worldwide. But it embodies far more than the sum of its remarkable elements, some transcending spatial and temporal lines, some invisibly reinforcing them. ■